

8 Engineering English Lines That Stop a Design Review Delay

Eight lines for the meeting where you are technically right and outranked. These are not vocabulary words. They are the exact sentences a senior engineer uses, in the order they use them.

The eight phrases

The same eight lines, now with the pronunciation and the reason each one works. Listen, then say each out loud.

1/8

Before we move on, can I add one thing?

/bɪ'fɔː wiː muːv ɒn kæn aɪ æd wʌn θɪŋ/

GETTING INTO THE CONVERSATION

INSTEAD OF Sorry, sorry, can I just say something?

Why it works. You ask for one thing, not for the floor. It is small, so it is easy to say yes to. Sorry sorry tells the room you are interrupting. This tells them you are helping.

Before we move on, can I add one thing about the routing?

Bago po tayo tumuloy, maaari po ba akong magdagdag ng isang bagay?

2/8

We both want this to go out once. I see the routing differently.

/wi: bæʊθ wɒnt ðɪs tu: gəʊ aʊt wʌns aɪ si: ðə 'ru:tɪŋ 'dɪfrəntli/

DIFFERING WITHOUT CONTRADICTING

INSTEAD OF No, that is not right.

Why it works. The shared goal goes first and the difference goes second. Now you are not against the senior person. You are two people trying to get one job out.

We both want this to go out once, not twice. I see the routing differently.

Pareho po nating gusto na minsan lang itong ilabas. Iba lang po ang tingin ko sa ruta.

3/8

I have checked it twice, and the numbers are in the pack.

/aɪ hæv tʃɛkt ɪt təwaɪs ænd ðə 'nʌmbəz ɑ: ɪn ðə pæk/

MAKING IT CHECKABLE

INSTEAD OF I think there might be a problem.

Why it works. Being sure is not the win. The win is that checking you is now cheap. Page nine does that work. You have moved the room from trusting you to looking for themselves.

I have checked it twice, and the numbers are in the pack, page nine.

Dalawang beses ko na po itong sinuri, at nasa pack po ang mga numero.

4/8

I take your point. I am still not comfortable issuing it as it stands.

/aɪ teɪk jɔː poɪnt aɪ æm stɪl nɒt 'kʌmfɪtəbl 'ɪʃuːɪŋ ɪt æz ɪt stændz/

HOLDING YOUR POSITION IN PUBLIC

INSTEAD OF Okay. If you are happy with it.

Why it works. I take your point says you understood the argument. I hear you only says you heard the sound. And not comfortable is about your own work. Nobody in that room can overrule it.

I take your point on the programme. I am still not comfortable issuing it as it stands.

Nakukuha ko po ang punto ninyo. Hindi pa rin po ako komportable na ilabas ito nang ganito.

5/8

If we leave it, we pay for it in week six.

/ɪf wiː liːv ɪt wiː peɪ fɔːr ɪt ɪn wiːk sɪks/

SAYING IT IN WEEKS

INSTEAD OF It is technically incorrect.

Why it works. Nobody in that room is paid to care about a drawing. They are paid to care about time. Say the cost in weeks and the room wakes up.

If we leave it, we pay for it in week six, on site, with a crane.

Kung hahayaan po natin ito, babayaran natin ito sa ikaanim na linggo.

6/8

Is that a no, or is that a not yet?

/ɪz ðæt ə nəʊ ɔːr ɪz ðæt ə nɒt jet/

TURNING A BRUSH-OFF INTO AN ANSWER

INSTEAD OF Okay, no problem.

Why it works. A soft maybe costs you six weeks. This question is polite and it has only two answers. Either one lets you plan.

Is that a no, or is that a not yet? I can bring it back Thursday.

Hindi po ba talaga, o hindi lang po sa ngayon?

7/8

Can we have that in the minutes?

/kæn wiː hæv ðæt ɪn ðə 'mɪnɪts/

PUTTING IT ON THE SHARED RECORD

INSTEAD OF I will send an email about it.

Why it works. An email is a thing you sent. The minutes are a thing the room agreed. One is your word against theirs later. The other is already everyone's. You are not warning anybody. You are asking the note taker to do their job.

Can we have that in the minutes? The clash, and the date we agreed to look at it.

Maaari po bang isama iyon sa minutes ng pulong?

8/8

Who is taking that, and by when?

/hu: ɪz 'teɪkɪŋ ðæt ænd baɪ wen/

TURNING AGREEMENT INTO A TASK

INSTEAD OF Great, thanks everyone.

Why it works. The chair asking this is routine. You asking it is not. So say it flat, and say it before anyone stands up. In a room of five, a job with no name is nobody's job.

Who is taking that, and by when? I can do it by Thursday.

Sino po ang bahala diyan, at hanggang kailan?

The steps

This is the sequence. It does not change.



Enter • Aim • Proof • Decide

Four steps. If you remember nothing else in that room, remember that order. A senior colleague who hears a small ask, then a shared aim, then a number they can check, almost always stops and listens.

Now you produce it

Write your answer first, then compare. Retrieving the phrase from a situation is what moves it into the language you can actually use under pressure. There is more than one right answer.

1. The chair is about to move to the next item and you have not spoken.

Before we move on, can I add one thing?

You ask for one thing, not for the floor. It is small, so it is easy to say yes to. Sorry sorry tells the room you are interrupting. This tells them you are helping.

2. A senior engineer has just approved a layout you do not agree with.

We both want this to go out once. I see the routing differently.

The shared goal goes first and the difference goes second. Now you are not against the senior person. You are two people trying to get one job out.

3. You have said there is a problem. Now make it something they can check.

I have checked it twice, and the numbers are in the pack.

Being sure is not the win. The win is that checking you is now cheap. Page nine does that work. You have moved the room from trusting you to looking for themselves.

4. A senior colleague has pushed back, and the whole room is waiting for you to fold.

I take your point. I am still not comfortable issuing it as it stands.

I take your point says you understood the argument. I hear you only says you heard the sound. And not comfortable is about your own work. Nobody in that room can overrule it.

5. Nobody in the room cares about the drawing. Tell them what it costs.

If we leave it, we pay for it in week six.

Nobody in that room is paid to care about a drawing. They are paid to care about time. Say the cost in weeks and the room wakes up.

6. You have been given a soft maybe and the meeting is ending.

Is that a no, or is that a not yet?

A soft maybe costs you six weeks. This question is polite and it has only two answers. Either one lets you plan.

7. The room has moved on and nothing has been written down.

Can we have that in the minutes?

An email is a thing you sent. The minutes are a thing the room agreed. One is your word against theirs later. The other is already everyone's. You are not warning anybody. You are asking the note taker to do their job.

8. The room has agreed something. Make sure it is somebody's job.

Who is taking that, and by when?

The chair asking this is routine. You asking it is not. So say it flat, and say it before anyone stands up. In a room of five, a job with no name is nobody's job.

Come back to this

Two situations, on the two days the research says matter. Say the phrase out loud before you look at the list again.

3/day **Day 3**

Three days ago you learned the four steps: enter, aim, proof, decide. New situation. The meeting is on a call, not in a room, and three people are talking over each other. Which of the four steps is hardest on a call, and which sentence would you open with?

7/day **Day 7**

One week in. This is the one people get wrong. You were right, the meeting went the other way, and six weeks later the problem has arrived exactly as you said it would. Two lines from this lesson still work here, and one of them is something you already said in that meeting. Can you remember which?

